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The early days

From school days to a tough start in the senior ranks … and fun along the way

‘Today,’ he said, ‘I am going to kill you.’

And there was no reason not to believe him.

He was tall and swarthy, with a mean look in his eye. I shat myself. What the hell was I doing here? I was only 16; I had my whole life ahead of me. Things were supposed to be sunny, bright and full of hope. Instead, as I squinted through the gap between the visor and metal guard of my helmet, I could see my killer thundering towards me. Tertius Bosch had a very long run-up, which, while it might have added a few extra seconds to my rapidly diminishing life span, also gave me what seemed like forever to contemplate my fate.

Fortunately I managed to survive the Northern Transvaal pace bowler’s onslaught on 26 December 1990 at Newlands, but the moment was indicative of how out of depth I felt playing cricket at that level. I mean, the guy put the fear of God into me. From this baptism-by-fire debut, it took a good three years before I could honestly say that I was comfortable batting against bowlers of Tertius’s calibre. Facing schoolboy fast bowlers was one thing; facing the likes of Tertius, Allan Donald and Brett Schultz in my first season of senior cricket was another ball game altogether.

Up until that stage, cricket had come easy to me. They bowled the ball to me; I made them go fetch it. That suited me. I reckon I was about 10 when I first began to get an idea that I was pretty good at the game. I attended St Joseph’s College in Rondebosch, Cape Town, and every time a pupil took six wickets or made 100 runs, they used to have a little ceremony at